

“ They want me to **write differently** ... I could, but **I must not. God** has ... given me this talent. It is to Him that I must **give account.**”

ANTON BRUCKNER

Early years in rural Austria

Bruckner's father, a good-natured man, encouraged his son's musical talent: aged only 10, young “Tonerl” would deputize for him as organist at the church. There were early signs, too, of Bruckner's obsessive streak: he was capable of practicing the organ for 12 hours at a stretch. The defining event in his early life was when his parents first took him to the nearby Augustinian monastery of St. Florian, with its large and ornately decorated Baroque church, impressive organ, and extensive cloisters and living quarters. For Bruckner, a devout Roman Catholic from his earliest years, St. Florian represented spiritual and musical paradise.

His fine treble voice enabled him to become a chorister there, and he studied the violin besides the organ. When the time came to leave, he decided to become a teacher like his father, and did a year's training in Linz. His first position was as assistant schoolmaster in the tiny village of Windhaag, where additional